unsuccessful in his attempt to arrest the communist leadership, ultimately leading to full-scale civil war.

U Nu felt that building a coalition with members of the People's Volunteer Organization (PVO) along with socialist and moderate communist party members was the best plan to create stability in Burma. Ultimately, the coalition plan faltered as factions of the PVO decided to rebel.

THE KAREN INSURGENCY

The Karen situation was unique compared to other minority populations in Burma. The Karens were a tribal group that migrated from China in the seventh century. Nationalism within the Karen community is tied to Christianity, which sets the group apart from the majority Buddhist in Burma. Furthermore, the Karen population had suffered abuse at times under the Burmese monarchy. By the late-19th century, Karen nationalism was readily apparent with the formation of the National Karen Association. The Karens decided to work with the British colonizers. Following brutal treatment during the Japanese occupation, Karen leaders clamored for a separate Karen state.

The relationship between the Karens and Burman were aggravated during the period of British colonial rule. Following independence this distrust only worsened. The Karen leadership believed that the British had promised the Karens an independent state. The decision was made to boycott the Constitutional Assembly elections scheduled for 1947. Tension was high at the time of Aung San's assassination in July 1947. The Karen were led by Saw Ba U Gyi. The formal or official break occurred during the meeting at Moulmein in late 1947. The group demanded complete separation and a sizeable independent state for the Karen population. Justin Windle, author of *Perfect Hostage: A Life of Aung San Suu Kyi, Burma's Prisoner of Conscience*, states that Saw Ba U Gyi expressed the four key demands of the Karens: “There shall be no surrender; recognition of a Karen state must be secured; the Karen's shall always retain their own arms; the Karen's must decide their own political destiny.” (184). The AFPFL rejected the Karen National Union's proposal for a separate state.